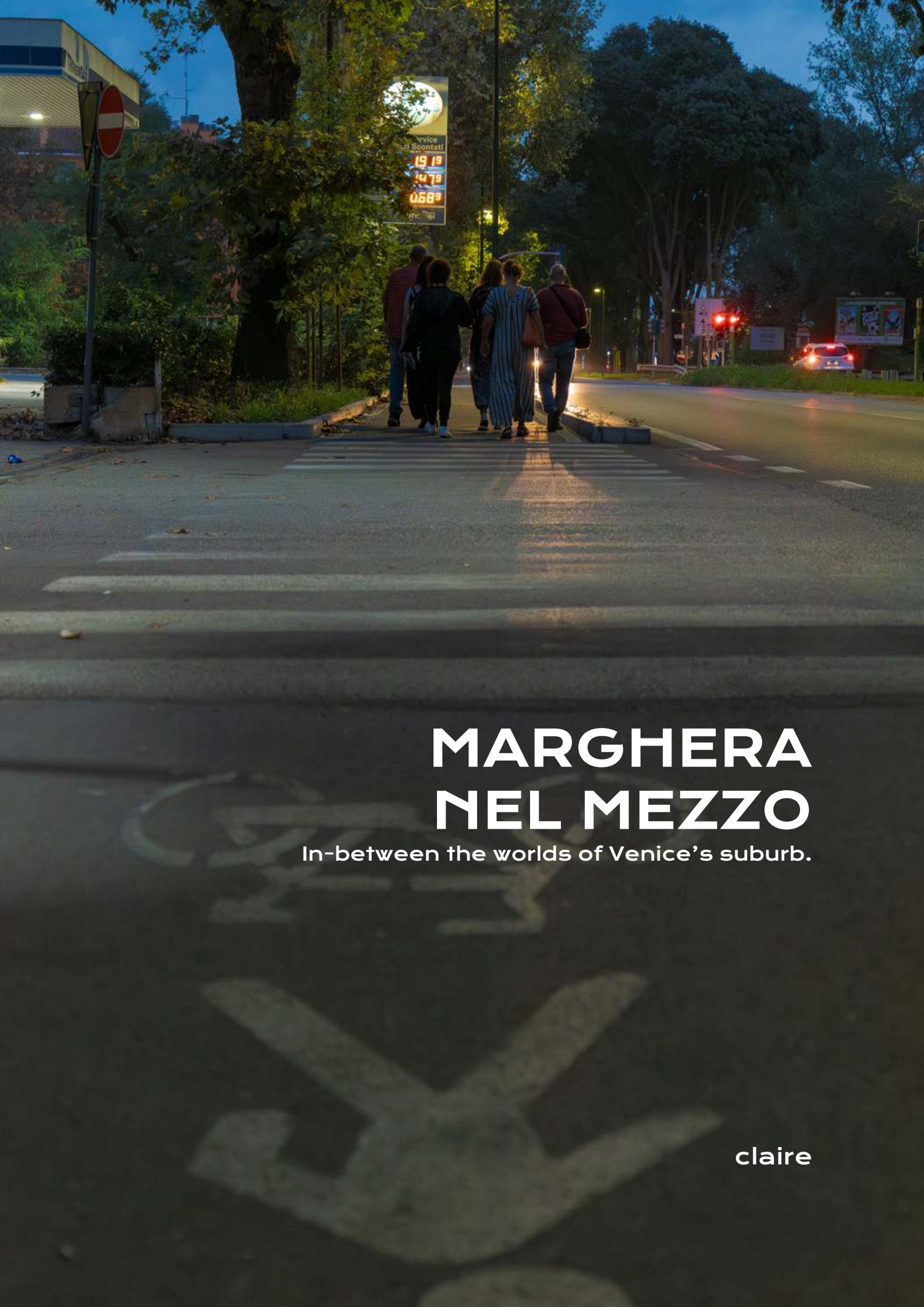




MARGHERA NEL MEZZO

In-between the worlds of Venice's suburb.

claire

To dad.

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What you need to know before diving into this report

GLOSSARY

Colonial language:

language that has bias that reflect the colonial power dynamics (use of words such as *other, savage, wild, us/them, culture/nature, civilised/uncivilised*).

Conviviality:

to quote *Tools for Conviviality* by Ivan Illich (1973, p. 11), *I consider conviviality to be individual freedom realised in personal interdependence and, as such, an intrinsic ethical value.*

Cosmopolitan realism (Ikas & Wagner, 2008):

the fact that, nowadays, our actions have an impact on other parts of the world, regardless of our location.

Pluriverse:

like in Arturo Escobar's work *Designs for the Pluriverse* (2018), I use the term to indicate the multitude of worlds that simultaneously exist and are inherently interconnected.

DESIGN APPROACH

In this section, I state the **what, how, where** and **why** of my practice as a designer for (more) sustainable futures.

What

identity and sense of belonging

How

participatory research, mutual aid, co-operation, participation, celebration of diversity, storytelling, queering, interaction, human-more than human interaction, technology, materiality

Where

place-based, but aware of the interconnectedness of all places

Why

justice, liberation, togetherness

INTRODUCTION

In this report, I explore my journey from research to design of the intervention proposed with my *design in action* project.

In Chapter 1, I present my positionality and the context behind my place-based project.

In Chapter 2, I talk about archival research, three interviews, one book reading and one online questionnaire, and continue with the explanation of the research done through an action-based participatory method (group walk). I took great care in conducting all primary research. For example, I tailored the consent forms for each interview to accommodate people's specific needs. I also considered the power dynamics in each method and tried to level disparities between myself and the participants by showing empathy and active listening. For each in-person group gathering, I provided small gifts and a free buffet. The evidence can be found in the visual documentation.

In Chapter 3, I delineate the idea behind my intervention, mention the projects that inspired it, walk the reader through the development of the process of co-design and showcase potential futures. This stage of the process proves the central position of collaboration and co-design.

After exposing outcomes and evaluation, I close the report with the summary of my process and with some final thoughts.

Chapter 1

WHY MARGHERA

CONSEQUENCES OF CAPITALISM IN THE GLOBAL NORTH AND IN MARGHERA

When I was little, I knew nothing about Marghera's role in global scale affairs. I only knew that it was a special place that people feared, hated and appreciated in equal amounts.

The suburb located in the first mainland just outside Venice, was built in 1917, in the middle of World War I. At the time, the highest authorities of the country cancelled the pre-existing local administrations and moved the power to Venice, *de facto* deploying the decision-making procedures outside of the interested area¹.



Figure 1 (left) 'Map of Italy', created by Chiara Portinari, 2023.

Figure 2 (right) 'Map of a portion of the Venetian Lagoon' showing the industrial (purple) and the residential (green) area of Marghera and its distance from Venice. Created by Chiara Portinari, 2023.

¹ Even though today Marghera counts more than 28k residents, it is still part of the Metropolitan City of Venice, together with Mestre and other Municipalities of the area (Comune di Venezia, 2023). The top-down administrative approach is still perceived by some of the residents, who recognise the great personal economic interests of the ruling class that gives only little recognition to the environmental, human and cultural value of the area, in favour of the accumulation of wealth for themselves (Tornielli, 2021).

After turning the swampy area into a construction site, they started to build the first industries and a state-of-the-art port facing the Venetian lagoon.

At its side, it began to appear an idyllic residential area called *Città Giardino*², with large avenues and small houses with gardens all around, designed to house the workers and their families.

Today, the two areas are neatly separated by Via Fratelli Bandiera, a road that connects the North-East of Italy to the centre of the country, and that before was an embankment from which you could see the lagoon³.

On the brink of an environmental disaster caused by capitalistic choices, I considered some of the major consequences that the Global North is currently facing, trying to find out how these translate locally to Marghera, a place meant to be a perfect capitalistic machine:

- a. the need to meet **sustainability goals** in the shortest possible amount of time,
- b. the intense **migrations** of climate and war refugees,
- c. the **loss of biodiversity**,
- d. the need to recognise and stop the **exploitation** carried on to the detriment of the Global South and of the local territory and community,
- e. the growth of the **economic gap** between rich and poor people.

Before even researching on these topics, as a local, I could already see how Marghera's history touched all these points.

The industrial area of Marghera has been one of the greatest polluters in Italian history, responsible of **environmental disasters** in terms of water, air and land pollution, at the expense of hundreds of human lives and precious biodiversity⁴.

Even though the advancement of technology reduced the contribution to work placement in the area, Marghera still represents one of the major Italian destinations for people who

² The Garden City, adapted by Pietro Emilio Emmer from the homonymous model of the English urban planner Ebenezer Howard.

³ Today, the industrial area does not allow people to access the waterfront, topic that has been central for projects such as The VEGA Waterfront (Vega Engineering, 2017).

⁴ It is to be noted that one of the most disconcerting facts happened during a Maxi Trial in 2001: 28 managers at the head of the industries Montedison and Enichem were charged with 157 cases of death and 103 cases of illness by polyvinyl-chloride operators, and environmental disaster caused by polyvinyl-chloride emissions (35 illegal dumps); a couple of hours before the proclamation of the sentence, the Ministry of the Environment received lire 525 billion as a compensation for environmental damages. All managers were acquitted in first grade. (Benatelli, 2017).

are willing to take in manufacturing jobs *in nero*⁵; at the end of last Century the largest number of migrants looking for a job were arriving from the South of Italy, since 10 or 15 years ago the migrants are mainly from other countries of the Global South. Marghera also hosts a great number of **refugees** from North Africa, East Europe and the Middle East who arrive by sea or by land. As the current far-right government's prevailing narrative legitimises racist, misogynist and negationist behaviours, I assume⁶ intercultural co-existence will be increasingly more challenging.

Where undocumented people are in high numbers, **organised crime** is usually also present. Illegal traffic of drugs and prostitution are particularly active in the area, controlled by international criminal organisations.

In addition to that, another factor is changing the territory and this time it has a perfectly legal asset to rely on: **mass tourism**. Venice, a major international destination, is only one bridge away from Marghera and allows tourism companies⁷ to generate an insane amount of profit for themselves. On the 8th of September 2023, the Associations OCIO and Venessia.com reported that, based on data from the General Register Office of Venice, the number of beds for tourists overtook the number of residents, rapidly decreasing due to lack of infrastructures to support everyday life and to the **rising costs of living**. Every day, Marghera hosts hundreds, if not thousands of tourists who cannot afford to sleep in Venice and travel there in the morning to only return late at night.

All these facts seem to have the incredible power of creating factions, division among people. As a designer for (more) sustainable futures who grew up in that territory and has first-hand experience in sharing that specific space with those specific issues, I questioned myself upon the possible strategies that Marghera should adopt to try and avoid reaching a point of no return, where those issues uncontrollably take over the space and break it.

⁵ Cash in hand, uninsured and most of the time underpaid. It is the only option for people with no documents in a country where refugees must deal with an incredibly intricate bureaucracy and – at the moment – a far-right government that is not willing to collaborate or make things any easier.

⁶ Believe.

⁷ International capitalists.

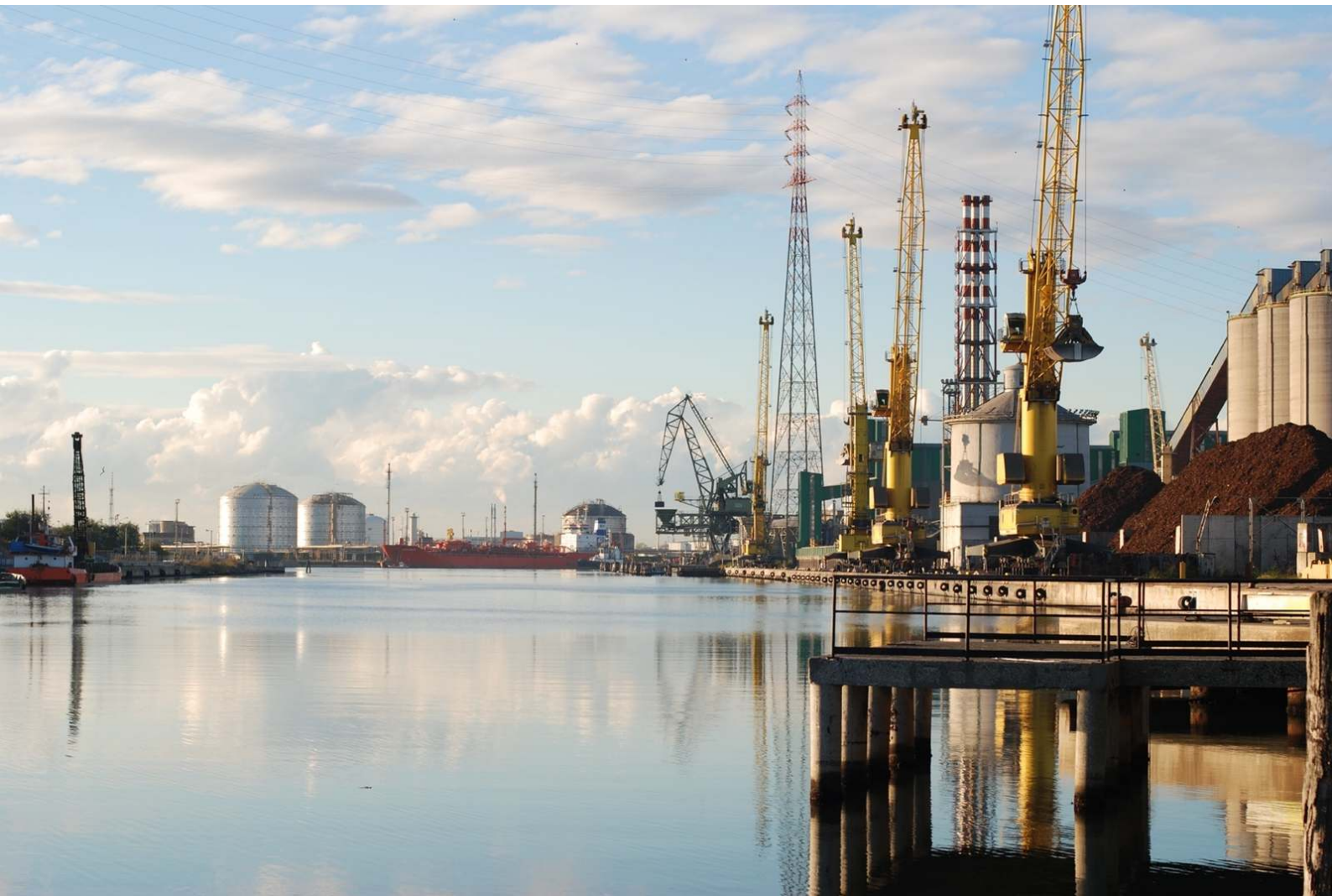


Figure 3 Crozzoletto, 2007. 'Porto Marghera'.



Figure 4 Archivio Margherini DOC, 1956. Aerial view of the urban area of Marghera.

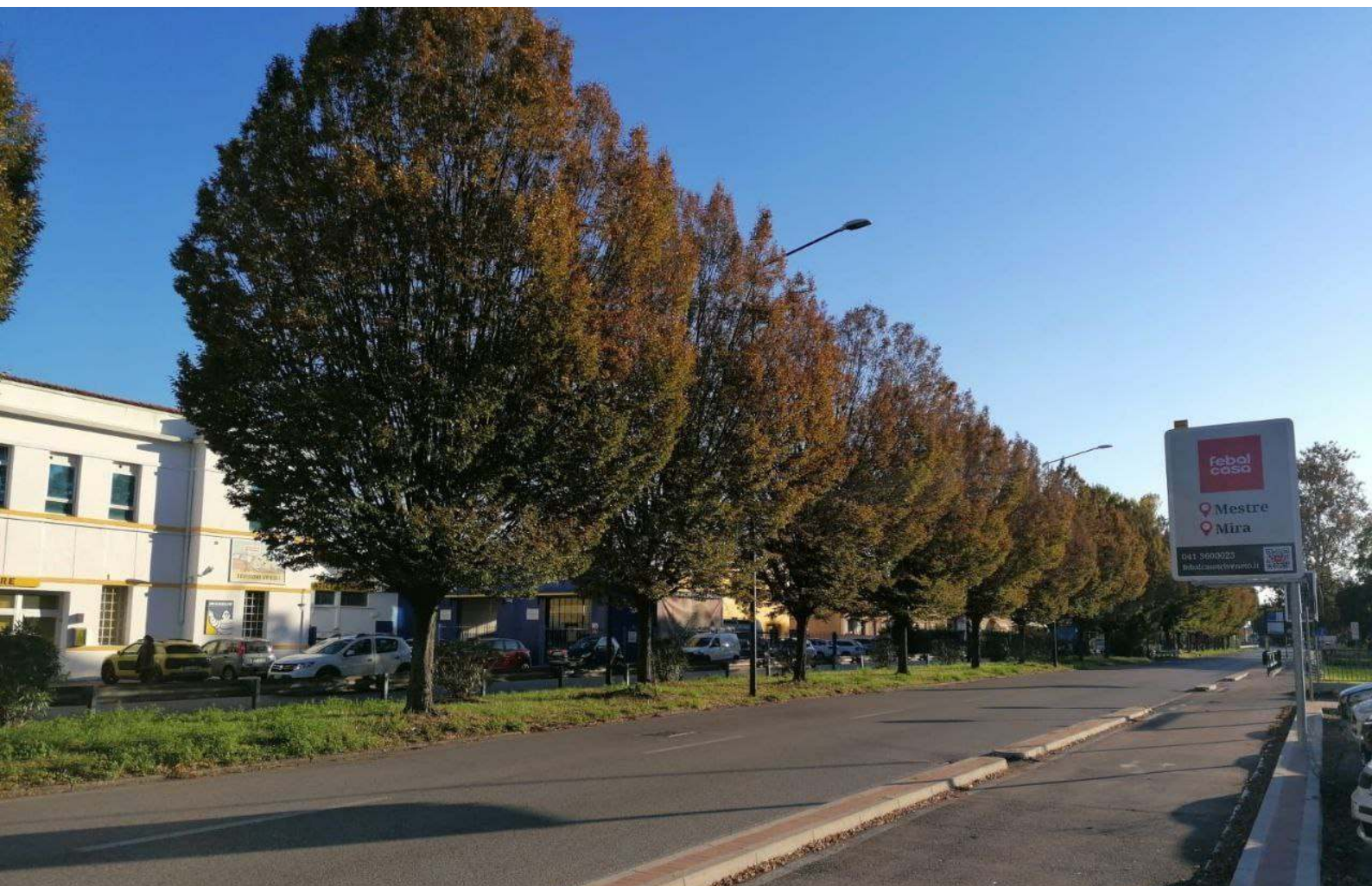


Figure 5 Portinari, L., 2023. 'Via Fratelli Bandiera'.

Chapter 2

MARGHERA IN-BETWEEN ...AND BEYOND

2.1 – MARGHERA’S IDENTITY – The archival research shows the history of cooperation in Marghera

Searching through the archives, it is certainly easy to find material such as photographs of the stages of the construction of the residential and industrial areas, maps of the territory before and after the industrialisation and urban designs.



Figure 6 – ‘Primary School Filippo Grimani’, created by Chiara Portinari, 2023.

Figure 7 – ‘The market squar’e’, created by Chiara Portinari, 2023.

Figure 8 – ‘Sant’Antonio Church and square’, created by Chiara Portinari, 2023.

Figure 9 – ‘My grandfather sitting on a bench in front of Sant’Antonio Church’, created by Chiara Portinari, 2023.

Many photographs show the community's actions that the people of Marghera took in their attempt to improve social justice in the workplace, demanding fair pay and conditions to sustain a healthy life.

According to the registry of associations of the municipality of Marghera (Comune di Venezia, 2023), there are 250 active associations in the territory, proving that it has a natural **inclination to cooperation**. This means that there is almost one association every 100 resident. I wonder if the sense of togetherness has been forged during the history of factory life of the first residents, which not only worked but fought together for their rights, supporting each other for the common good.

As an 'insider' to the culture, I feel the need to protect this inclination from the dividing forces of capitalism.



Figure 10 'Manufacturing workers during a demonstration in 1982', created by Chiara Portinari, 2023. Illustration based on an archive photograph found in the Archivio Fondo Giacomelli.

2.2 – A COMFORTING DEFINITION OF COMMUNITY – A survey exposes traces of division

To explore what books and photographs could not explain, I prepared and distributed via social media and messaging apps an online survey addressing people who have or have had something to do with the suburb. With this method, I wanted to compare the inclination to community to the inclination to division in Marghera. I looked for patterns in the use of colonial language, in topics and in symbols.

I asked five open questions about:

- the symbols of Marghera,
- the aspects of Marghera that they consider interesting,
- the places or topics that in their opinion the residents and the local educational programs should pay attention to,
- the places where they feel they are part of the community,
- the places in Marghera they have not visited yet and that they would like to go to.

The survey ended with the possibility to add a free sentence as a contribution to the research about Marghera.

Using the survey as a research method gave me the opportunity to look at some of the assumptions I was basing my work on; for example, I found a sense of detachment from their sense of identity in 11% of the people's answers. Several of them blamed the fact that they do not recognise the suburb anymore because they see different people walking its streets: "Marghera is not owned by people of Marghera anymore" or "Marghera is not the same as before". Those are patterns of colonial language, that signal a hostile environment that encourages *division* and *individualism* as a defence weapon against what is considered **other** or unknown.

Supporting another assumption, more than 21% of people shared a sentence that shows a feeling of scepticism towards the ability of the current administration to properly deal with the issues and potentials of Marghera, mentioning the missed opportunity of benefiting from the proximity with Venice, the need for a requalification of the industrial area, the necessity of prioritising public services currently ignored or underfunded.

Setting the display of discontent aside, I wanted to find what represents Marghera in the imaginary of the people. One answer stands upon the others with 43 entries⁸ out of 128: the tower of the aqueduct.

⁸ It is important to note that people did not have the task to select their answers from multiple options, but they had to come up with their own response, suggested only by their thoughts and beliefs.



Figure 11 'The tower of the aqueduct', created by Chiara Portinari, 2023.

Massive, unmistakable, unmovable, the tower can be seen from afar, it announces the proximity of Marghera when traveling back from out-of-town, and it is well framed by the urbanistic. A well-thought iconic opportunity. It was no surprise to me, but it made me reflect on how people tend to choose an old and (apparently) unchanging building as a symbol of their territory and add to its bare function the role of comforting the people from their chaotic existence.

Following the tower of the aqueduct, 22 people indicated the main market square – sign of an attachment to the oldest and most practical activities carried out by the locals. 12 mentioned the prominent greenery of the area, that we are all proud of; 10 the industries; 8 the roundabouts⁹. Some mentioned specific roads, other the oldest ice-cream shop or the pubs, but the answer that struck me were “the smile of the people” and their “folkloric spirit”. Those are signs of connection, signs of contact, fundamental aspects of active engagement in the community.

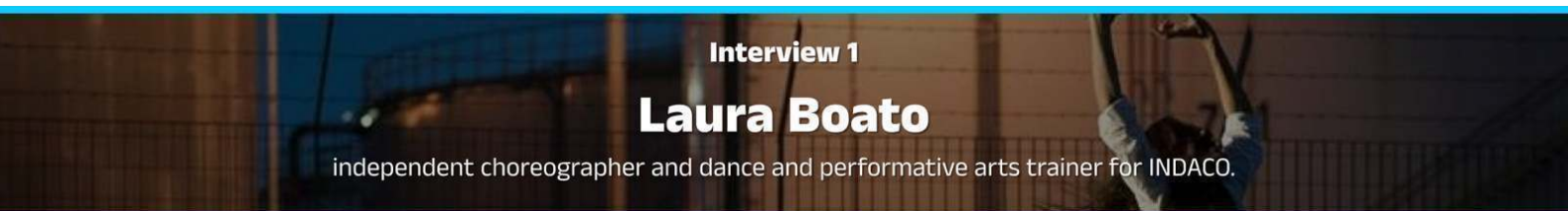
⁹ Particularly mocked by people living in the near-by cities who historically approach them as driving tests before obtaining their license.

Connection, contact, engagement, community.

Those are the concepts that my project focused on, as they are the forces which can counteract the division that I started to gather evidence of.

2.3 – WHAT IF BEING IN A COMMUNITY IS NOT SO COMFORTABLE? – The conversation with community experts expands the definition of identity

In this section, I report the main findings of three interviews done with community experts from cultural environments, and a reflection on a book suggestion. I follow with a consideration on the learnings gained from each method.



During an online interview done in July 2023, **Laura Boato** talked to me about *Mar Gh'Era*¹⁰, the itinerant performance that she co-wrote and directed for the 100th anniversary of Porto Marghera. It is a theatre-dance show that tells the story of the suburb, paying attention to its achievements, but underlining the **costs** entailed.

Boato directed an impressive cast of more than 100 performers, and managed to set up the show even though the Municipality did not give any economic support¹¹. She told me about the challenges of organising the rehearsals and the show with so many independent artists and amateurs, but also the easiness of finding help and collaborative spirit from the locals.

She told me how the audience (composed by around 1000 people) enthusiastically accompanied the performers throughout the location despite a gradually more adverse weather. Walking together represented a common goal, an action that defined the group

¹⁰ It is common for residents to say that the word Marghera comes from the dialect *Mar ghe gera* (shortened in *mar gh'era*), which means *There was the sea*. It is quite a romantic interpretation that reflects the attachment of the residents to the lagoon, but it is not the official etymology (which is not clear to this day).

¹¹ For the Centenary of Porto Marghera a series of events was organised to celebrate all the achievements, but who was talking about the costs?

as one, breaking the power-dynamic that the contraposition of stage and audience usually entails. People did not just watch the show, they were part of it.

Boato mentioned the messages full of emotions about the show that she kept receiving for the whole month following the event. It looked like people were *in need of a representation* where *their whole story* was told, without vital missing pieces.

As philosopher and social critic Ivan Illich proposed, there might not be technological achievement that satisfies the need it creates (1973, p. 11): Marghera's need for authentic participation and recognition might not be fulfilled by the achievements of the capitalist powers that operate in the area through the industries and multinational companies.

Using a cross-analysis technique, I explored the answers of the questionnaire in search for signals of the need for authentic representation perceived during the experience of *Mar Gh'Era*. I ended up with an interesting data: 40% of the people who completed the survey remarked the importance of having the history of Marghera taught in local schools, and almost a quarter of those specified how the human part of it should be included.

These numbers could be emerging because of the history of **exploitation** of human capital that Marghera has and that has not yet been officially acknowledged.



The semi-structured interview with **StorieStorte** made me realise how hard it is to separate the activity of the music duo from that of other local initiatives such as *Mar Gh'Era*. In fact, the duo is working on projects together with the local choir Voci dal Mondo¹² and with Mc Bible¹³, and they are present at most of the events about remembrance and celebration of inclusion that the territory offers.

During our chat, Corinna Venturini considered the difficulties of being activist-artists and sharing spaces with people who might fight in different ways to protect the same values, but she nurtures the potential of **diversity**: where there is none, we address issues by synthesizing and reducing information; where there is, we multiply the opportunities.

¹² A choir funded on the union of Italian and foreign voices, coming together as a diverse and strong collaboration.

¹³ Art name of Festus Ogieriekhi, migrant artist.

StorieStorte's spontaneous actions, faithful to their beliefs and to the message they want to pass on, are the demonstration of how one can be *one* by being *part*, a couple of terms that have an organic meaning if put together, rather than when divided. It is hard, though, to live this way in a world where even artists are pushed to compete against each other for chasing the impossible (and probably not satisfying) dream of success.

StorieStorte do not dream of being rich and famous, they would just love to be able to spend more time bringing their music in social occasions, building more inclusive futures.

Interview 3

ViviAmo Marghera

Local Committee spontaneously born from a group of residents.

Division within the population can be supported by stigmas, too. As in many suburbs of the Global North, like Greater Manchester in the UK for example¹⁴, the war on drugs can exacerbate the relationship between the residents. The Committee **ViviAmo Marghera** believes that the issue is not well-addressed (or not addressed at all) in the area and they are trying to bring attention to the aspects that the administration lacks.

During an online interview, two representatives of ViviAmo Marghera told me how, over the past months, they worked hard for gathering data about the consumption of drugs. They approached people with lived experience of drug use and listened to their stories. They asked them to fill in a survey about their needs and rights. They also proposed a general questionnaire to all residents about the perception of safety, where they could express their thoughts and concerns.

ViviAmo Marghera is not only gathering information useful for the socio-political conversation they hope to open with the administration, but they are also experiencing the power that knowledge has of making the fear of the unknown fade away. They themselves became aware of their biases towards people who consume drugs and learnt that more awareness means more control over simplistic and often misleading stigmas.

Book reading

La Linea dell'Orizzonte

Book suggested by the owner of the local independent bookshop Heimat, in the centre of Marghera.

¹⁴ I am referring to the opioid crisis of the recent years.

Listening to the introduction of my project, many people suggested me to contact the guys who run **Heimat**¹⁵, the independent bookstore bravely opened in the centre of Marghera during the Covid-19 pandemic in 2020. The shop is home to many book presentations, community meetings and events, and openly works as a converging point for the energies of the territory.

One of the two owners who started this place-centred activity, seemed to have grasped very well the spirit of my research and offered their help by pointing out many other local initiatives to look at, and (of course) several books to read.

One of these was *La linea dell'orizzonte* (2021) by Francesco Della Puppa, Francesco Matteuzzi and Francesco Saresin, who turned Della Puppa's research into a comic-book. The story follows the researcher journey through his discovery of a phenomenon that brings Bangladeshi families to London after living in Italy for several years. It was suggested to me as it mentions Marghera as one of the locations where this happens the most. As briefly reported in Chapter 1, migration is a defining part of Marghera's formation and evolution, and *La linea dell'orizzonte* addresses a specific nuance that, once again, cannot be flattened by simplistic descriptions.

The kids of Bangladeshi families who grow up in Marghera often see in London a better destination that could allow them to fulfil their ambitions¹⁶. Though, when they leave Marghera, they bring their 'margheraness' with them, disconnecting the concept of identity from the physical territory.

In this story, Marghera is *destination*, *passage* and *start* of a migration flow, but it also is at the same time *in* Marghera and *somewhere else*.

With Laura Boato, I learnt about the urge for **authentic representation** as community-building tool and how this practice is not addressed nor supported by the administration. I also learnt how power-dynamics can be modified by abandoning traditional systems.

¹⁵ German word that has not exact translation but refers to the concept of home or homeland as an emotional space, or a place where comfort, clarity and transparency are perceived.

¹⁶ An idea that seems fair for a kid born in Italy from non-Italian parents, as being born there does not automatically imply receiving the Italian citizenship. The only way to obtain it is to wait until they reach the age of consent (having lived in Italy continuously since birth) and only then submit a request for the citizenship, starting a bureaucratically complex iter that, if successful, culminates in a ceremony where the person swears allegiance to the Constitution. To use the words that the musician and writer Anna Maria Gehnyei, daughter of Liberian parents, directed to an all-Italian audience during the presentation of her book *Il corpo nero* (2023): "How many of you had to swear allegiance to the Constitution to become Italian?" (Gehnyei, 2023). Obviously, none.

With *StorieStorte*, I got a sense of the potential of **living as one** with our own community, but also pointed out how capitalism is pushing (even) the artists to another direction.

With *ViviAmo Marghera*, I considered **awareness** and **knowledge** as powerful counter tools to social division, that in the area is so much supported by stigmas.

With *La Linea dell'Orizzonte*, I expanded the concept of community **beyond the limits of space**, and I became aware of how we are living in a cosmopolitan realism that is impossible to draw with lines.

When reading the questionnaire's answers with these four lenses, it is understandable that, even in a place where cooperation has always come natural, communities are facing **unprecedented challenges**.

2.4 – MAKING COMFORT INSIDE CHAOS – An action-based research method shapes one bit of Marghera's identity

To test the learnings that I gained from the interviews, I designed two walks opened to an adult public which took place along Via Fratelli Bandiera, Marghera's symbolic *in-between* road. I wanted to observe the interactions between people with potentially different backgrounds, assumptions and beliefs, while exploring the urban area and its connection to personal experiences¹⁷.



In both walks, we discussed the topic of cultural identity, which many agree takes the shape of the actions and the happenings that one¹⁸ can experience or perceive in or about that space. We shared our memories, recalling how smaller many of the trees were and how smelly the air was when some of the industries were active; we taught each other about the still visible signs of the embankment that preceded the road we were walking, and pointed at the oldest buildings we knew.

One sentence shared by one of the people who moved away from Marghera was particularly inspiring for me. I translate and rephrase it: "Even though Marghera has its

¹⁷ Psychogeography.

¹⁸ Not necessarily only a human.

issues, often quite visible, I feel safer here than in other cities". I asked if the fact of knowing the issues might be of help when sharing the space with those same issues. They agreed.

There were also some exchanges of opinions about which administration was to blame for the issues present in the area, but it looked like the conversation was carried out peacefully, even when the opinions were opposite.

When we actively engage with one space or one community, we gain knowledge about it, becoming more aware of its shape and textures. With that knowledge, if we feel the need to shape a more comfortable space for us, we are more confident in acting upon its malleable spots. This happens every time we make an action like walking, talking, asking or speaking up. If we consider a lifespan of small actions, those will have shaped that space or community for many of our needs and for the need of those that are like us. It will be there that we feel the most comfortable. If we divide ourselves from the rest of the community and do not make any action towards it, nor big or small, we will unlikely find a suitable space for us and we will recognise ourselves in that community less and less.



Figure 12 - (Mameli, 2023) Walk 2.



Figure 13 - (Mameli, 2023) Walk 1.

Chapter 3

MY PROPOSAL FOR AN OCCASION OF ENCOUNTER IN MARGHERA'S PLURIVERSE

3.1 – BEHIND THE DESIGN

In a territory where *division* and *individualism* are supported and legitimised by so many factors and have become biases, I believe design could intervene by proposing occasions of encounter and unity.

The nature of Marghera's identity is not only multifaceted, but also multidimensional: it is house to many different worlds (communities, cultures, families) that need to maintain or improve the sustainability of their coexistence to face all the forces that are pushing against it.

In my opinion, Marghera is not in a critical state, but it is important to create occasions to reinforce the positive attitude towards community life while preparing for a potentially bigger storm of change.

My intervention wants to be one of the occasions that people could grab – casually or not – to engage with the territory and the other worlds that inhabit it, to help shape that space and making it every day more comfortable for as much people as possible.

The projects that inspired me address the right for recognition and are themselves occasions of encounter with other worlds; they find in the action of engagement a tool for conviviality rather than a tool for gaining capital¹⁹ (Illich, 1973).

The archive (Wang & Vernon, 2019), for example, is a project that gives the possibility through a map to locate and recognise places that are important to the queer

¹⁹ I believe that, in any society, as conviviality is reduced below a certain level, no amount of industrial productivity can effectively satisfy the needs it creates among society's members. (Illich, 1973, p. 11)

community, offering everyone the possibility to get in touch with that specific world, but more importantly, giving queer people access to their own heritage.

A mile in my shoes (Patey, 2015) offers the opportunity to literally wear someone else's shoes and walk a mile while listening to a recording of their voices telling the participant a story they have lived. Particularly relevant for my project is the fact that *A mile in my shoes* continues to be proposed in different cities and every time reports local stories, different from those of the previous location.

These projects suggested me how to ground my design in the place it is meant for and in the organic contribution of the people involved.

3.2 – IN THE DESIGN

The aim is that of adding in Marghera small opportunities of encounter and recognition: we are planning to install in public spaces several totems representing **portals** that people can *open* to visit Marghera's *worlds*.

Two community experts (one independent bookstore owner and a professional from the Italian Coordination for Foreigners' Rights to Family Life), together with two locals and two expats, worked on connecting *places* and *topics* among those most recurring in the questionnaire²⁰.

The places were chosen as locations for the portals. The topics will give each portal a loose sense of what types of worlds you will be likely to jump to.

- **Identity, belonging and folkloric spirit**, to position in the Cita neighbourhood,
- **Identity, coexistence and the 5 senses**, to position in Piazzale Concordia,
- **Identity, territory and biodiversity**, to position in the industrial area.

²⁰ See visual documentation, 'Prototyping' section, p. 57-58.

I designed²¹ a temporary prototype of a portal (Fig. 14) in the shape of a birdfeeder²² merged with a *cippo di conterminazione lagunare*²³, but I am planning to co-design the official portals in several in-person workshops where the locals will be able to draw and share their thoughts. I will then synthesise their ideas into one or more concepts.

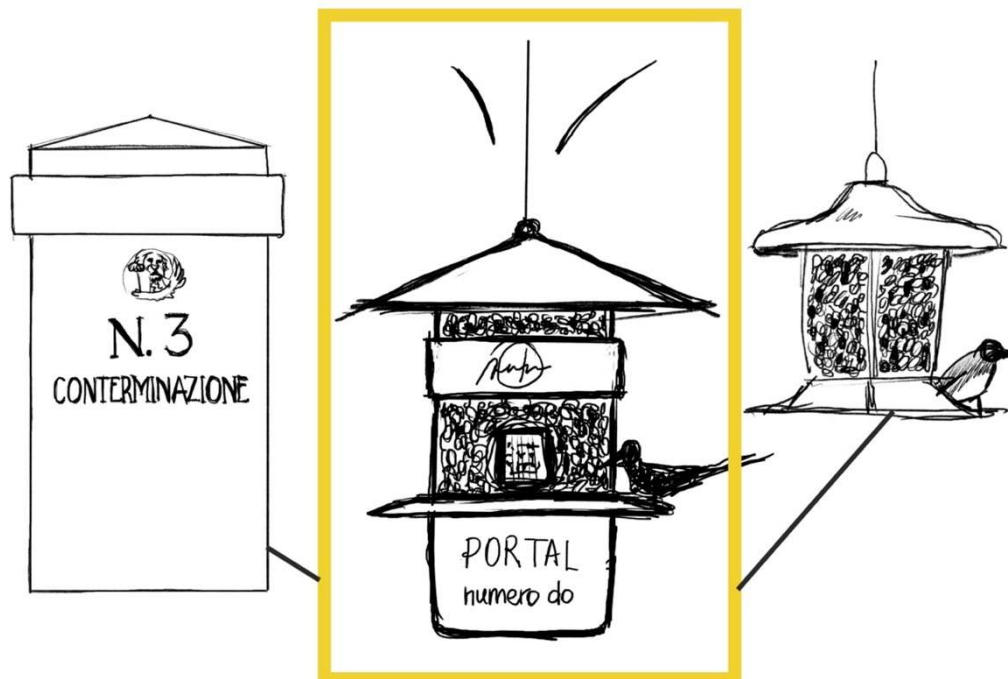


Figure 14 'Portal numero do' (translated from dialect: Portal number two), created by Chiara Portinari, 2023.

Every portal will embed a QR code that will lead to a web page where a random content will be shown²⁴. Images, texts, audios and videos – each one representing one world – will be randomly picked from a people-powered database. In the web page, in fact, a button will take people to a form to fill in, and where it will be possible to upload one's own content (therefore one's own world), which will be reviewed²⁵ and then approved. The web pages

²¹ See visual documentation, 'Prototyping' section, p. 60.

²² To encourage closeness of humans and more than humans, adding another metaphorical meaning to the junction between worlds.

²³ It is a stone that marks the boundary between the lagoon of Venice and the mainland. They were established in 1791 by the Republic of Venice for military protection, but they are still defining the boundaries of the lagoon today. In a swampy surrounding, it is difficult to establish where the *water* finishes and the *land* starts, so I decided to use their shape to symbolise the encounter of different worlds which are not so divided.

²⁴ See visual documentation, 'Prototyping' section, p. 59-60.

²⁵ The approval will involve only an ethical check aimed at protecting the most vulnerable people. It will not include a curatorial intervention.

will also be reachable from Google Maps²⁶. The visual content will be accompanied by alt-text descriptions written in a poetic form by an expat poet.

Another expat developer has already set the system up and we are currently working on testing and uploading some initial content for display purposes.

By co-designing a collaborative and participative system, I tried to avoid adding an educational and traditionally curatorial intervention which would sound partial and possibly patronising.

3.3 – BEYOND THE DESIGN

I consider myself satisfied with what we have achieved and with the network of people who are happy to continue working on the project. Their enthusiasm, together with the level of participation recorded, are certainly two of the major signals of success of this project.

Looking back at my research, I missed the chance of fine-tuning the questionnaire by adding accessibility tools which would have helped the project achieve its true purpose of inclusion, collecting numerous viewpoints and positionalities to celebrate diversity. Continuing this project after the end of the course, I will propose the questionnaire in more languages, in person and in appropriate places.

By using those tools properly, I will be able to gain even more useful information which will support a request for permissions and fundings for the realisation of the intervention. The success of this aspect will add a positive point to the evaluation of the project.

Moreover, once installed, I will have more opportunities to evaluate the project: I will observe the amount of engagement from the passers-by and the more-than-humans, and I will monitor the growth of the database.

The long-term goal is to open many other possibilities for the portals, such as using them as:

- **tools for self-reflection and storytelling** for locals (individuals and groups, possibly schools),
- **reference points for** mental and physical health **activities** (wellbeing walks for example),
- **touristic points** of interest,

²⁶ To include those who might not be able to reach the QR code in person and also to attract curious tourists.

- **symbols** of inclusion, hospitality and belonging.

Each of these points could answer to specific needs that Marghera is displaying:

- need for **authentic representation** - in the future, if the database grows, it could inform some aspects of Marghera's territorial, human and cultural identity, adding to the suburb's narrative²⁷ the authentic voices of the people who live the territory,
- need for **healthier opportunities** to develop their body-territory relationships - Marghera's reputation of toxicity connected to the activities of the industries could slowly shift if we encourage activities such as wellbeing walks,
- need to deal with **mass tourism** in Venice - the portals could be an occasion for tourists to engage with the mainland,
- need to **expand the knowledge** between the new **cultures** that are starting to coexist - little windows into each other worlds could show communities' authentic portraits, not based on assumptions.

²⁷ As a feminist socially focused designer, I firmly support what Ursula K. Le Guin theorised in *The Carrier Bag Theory of Fiction* (2020): the patriarchal narrative of the Global North needs to be challenged.

CONCLUSION

Inspired by its urban landscape where residential and industrial are neatly divided, I decided to explore Marghera's cultural identity which often revolves around dualisms, in search for a sign of unsustainability to address. I found out that capitalism is (not so) indirectly encouraging division in the population, breaking *us* from *them*, *past* from *future*, *administration* from *residents*. Sudden changes in its social fabric, for example, are pushing people to be firmer in choosing the comfort of the *already known*, that looks still and self-defining, over the uncertainty of the *yet to be known*, apparently chaotically moving and ineffable; the not-yet-recognised history of exploitation, the consequent growing gap between rich and poor and the relentless onslaught of mass tourism are all factors that could threaten Marghera's unique inclination to cooperation.

I looked for possible ways to maintain or improve acceptance and peaceful coexistence within a territory by learning from the experts and testing action-based methods such as group walks. I found out how participating in gentle and safe activities about territorial connections (where power dynamics are dismantled) could encourage harmony within a group.

Inspired by other design projects and through analysis and collaboration with the experts, I am co-designing a participative and interactive system that will offer the chance to make a step towards the unknown, to make coexistence and union more sustainable for everybody. Will portals to other worlds that exist within Marghera support people's unity through increasingly unstable times?

The enthusiasm and will to participate demonstrated by the people involved in the project invite me to continue working on it with passion and consistency, inspiring and being inspired by other similar projects which value conviviality over profit.

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